

Directory structure in Jekyll

- `_config.yml`: All the configuration steps that Jekyll uses are derived from here.
- `_includes`: This folder is for partial views.
- `_layouts`: This folder is for the main templates your content will be inserted into. You can have different layouts for different pages or page sections.
- `_posts`: This folder contains your dynamic content/posts. Jekyll expects the format to be `YYYY-MM-DD-post_title.md`. `_site`—this is where the generated site will be placed once Jekyll is done transforming it.

Looking at the directory structure that Jekyll created, you will notice a `_posts` subdirectory. This is where your published blog posts will reside. The file names should be of the format `YYYY-MM-DD-name-of-post.md`. Jekyll will automatically infer the date and permalink slug of your post from this name, unless overridden.

A new post can be created using the command line by using the following command:

```
rake post title="Hello World"
```

Replace this title with the title of your blog post.

Adding tags

Jekyll allows you to include metadata for your posts. Tags can be added to a post using the YAML (YAML Ain't Markup Language) front matter. These tags also get added to the site-wide collection.

Categories

Posts may be categorised by providing one or more categories in the YAML front matter. Categories can be reflected in the URL path of each post. Another important thing to be noted is that Jekyll will set a hierarchy of categories if you have specified more than one category name.

For example:

```
---
title : Hello World
tags : blog
categories : [blog, beginner]
---
```

This defines the category hierarchy 'blog/beginner'. Note that this is one category node in Jekyll. You won't find 'blog' and 'beginner' as two separate categories.

Plugins

Jekyll has many plugins that make your life easier. A Jekyll plugin can be installed in two different ways.

While within your site's root directory, create a `_plugins` directory. This directory is the source for all the plugins. Any Ruby file in this directory will be automatically loaded before

Jekyll generates your static content.

Alternatively, you can add the names of gems as plugins in your `_config.yml` file. These gems will be loaded when the site is served.

Here is an example:

```
gems: [jekyll-jsonify, jekyll-assets]
```

Some of the commonly used plugins are:

- Archive generator
- Sitemap generator
- Tag cloud generator
- RSS generator

Deploying your blog

Deploying to GitHub Pages

You can deploy Jekyll to your GitHub account and GitHub will take care of the rest. It will parse your repo through Jekyll, generate your static content and host the result under `username.github.com`. However, your Jekyll site will be built using the `—safe flag`, for security reasons. Hence, plugins will not work if you are hosting the site using GitHub Pages.

Deploying to custom server

If you prefer to host your site on your own private server, build the site using Jekyll's command `jekyll build` and copy the resulting static files to your Web server. One advantage of using a private server is that you will be able to use plugins inside Jekyll.

Custom plugins can be made to work with GitHub Pages by using an 'after commit' hook, or by building the static contents and then pushing them to your GitHub repo.

Custom domain support

GitHub Pages allow you to point your domain to it. Let's suppose you want to point your domain, `example.com`, to GitHub Pages. Create a new file named `CNAME` in the root of your repository and add your domain name as its contents.

All you need to do now is set up the DNS with your domain name registrar to point your domain to `yourname.github.com`

Migration from existing blogs

Jekyll provides a variety of importer scripts to help you import your existing blog from another platform to Jekyll. Importer scripts are available for Wordpress, Blogger, Tumblr, Movable type, etc. All these scripts need access to your database or to your blog's RSS feeds. These scripts will automatically import your existing blog posts into Jekyll. 

By: Manu S Ajith

The author is a self-taught programmer and hacker with expertise in Ruby on Rails, CoffeeScript, Web frameworks and other programming languages. He has a passion for Web 2.0 trends, APIs, mashups and other disruptive technologies. He blogs at <http://codingarena.in/>. You can follow him on twitter @manusajith